Chapter 1 — Mary Comes to England

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Mary Lennox lived in a large house in India, where many servants worked from morning until night.

The house was always full of sound. Doors opened and closed. Voices moved through the rooms. Footsteps passed outside her door again and again. Someone was always speaking, calling, or laughing.

Mary was not a happy child. She spent most of her time alone in her room. When she wanted something, she rang a bell, and a servant came quickly. Mary spoke sharply and did not wait. If people were slow, she became angry. No one told her to stop. No one asked her to change.

Her parents lived in the same house, but they were almost never with her. They had many guests and many parties. Music played in the evenings, and voices filled the air late into the night. Mary watched from her room and listened, but no

one called her to join them. She learned to stay quiet and watch.

Outside the house, the city was loud and bright. Carts moved through the streets. Animals cried. People shouted and laughed. The air was hot and heavy, and sound never stopped. Even at night, noise came through the open windows.

One morning, Mary woke up and felt something was different.

Everything stayed still.

No footsteps passed her door. No voices came from the halls. Mary sat up in bed and waited. She rang her bell.

No one came.

She rang it again, louder this time. Still no one came. Mary stood up and opened the door. The long hallway outside her room was empty. The floor shone, but no one walked there. Her own steps sounded strange in the silence, as if the house was holding its breath.

Later that day, adults came into the house. They spoke in low voices and closed many doors. They told Mary to stay in her room. She obeyed and waited, sitting on her bed and looking at the wall. Time moved slowly.

An illness had come to the house. People became sick very quickly. Some servants left at once. Others stayed, but not for long. Each day the house became quieter. Rooms stood empty, and doors stayed closed.

Mary stayed inside and waited.

A woman brought her food and water each day. She did not stay to talk. When Mary asked questions, the woman looked away and said nothing. The silence felt heavy and strange, and Mary did not know what to do with it.

After some days, another woman came to see Mary. She wore dark clothes and spoke in a calm, firm voice. She told Mary that her parents were gone. She said Mary would leave the house and travel to England, where her uncle lived.

Mary heard the words without speaking. She did not cry. She felt tired and empty, as if all the sound had left her too. She sat very still and held her hands together.

Soon after, Mary left the house where she had lived all her life.

She traveled first by carriage, sitting quietly as the road passed beneath the wheels. The city disappeared behind her. Houses stood farther apart, and the air began to change. Later, she traveled by ship across the sea.

The ship was large and slow. It smelled of wood and water. At night it moved and creaked, and the waves struck its sides again and again. Mary lay in her bed and heard the sound of the sea. The sea did not stop speaking, even when everything else was quiet.

During the day, Mary went out on deck and watched the water move again and again. The air felt different there. It was cooler and fresher than in India. The wind touched her face, and Mary pulled her coat close around her. She stood alone and watched the horizon for a long time.

For the first time in her life, she felt cold.

The days on the ship felt long. Mary slept often and ate little. She felt tired in a way she had never felt before. There were no servants nearby and no bells to ring. She did not speak to anyone, and no one spoke to her. The sound of the sea filled the empty space around her.

After many days, the ship arrived in England.

The sky was gray, and the air was wet and cold. Mary stood still and looked around as people hurried past her. She felt small among them. From the ship, she traveled again by carriage. The road was long and quiet. Fields stretched out on both sides, and the wind moved across them freely. There were no loud streets and no bright lights.

As the day passed, the light began to fade. Clouds covered the sky, and the land grew dark. The carriage moved on through the evening, and Mary watched the shadows outside the window.

At last, the carriage stopped in front of a large, dark house. It stood alone on the open land. No lights shone from the windows, and no sound came from inside.

This was Misselthwaite Manor.

A woman opened the door and spoke to Mary in a firm voice. Mary followed her inside. The air felt cold in the halls. Their steps echoed as they walked. Doors stood closed on both sides.

The woman led Mary up a long stair and along another quiet hall. At last she opened a door and told Mary this was

her room. Mary stepped inside and looked around. The room was large and bare.

Mary sat on the bed.

No voices came through the walls. No music played. Everything stayed still.

The door closed.

No sounds came from the house.

Chapter 2 — The Big Quiet House

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Mary woke early the next morning. For a moment, she did not remember where she was. The room felt cold and still. Then she remembered the long journey and the dark house. She sat up in bed and waited.

Everything stayed still.

No voices came through the walls. No doors opened or closed. Mary heard only a soft sound from outside, moving slowly past the windows. It rose and fell and did not stop.

She stood up and looked around the room. The walls were bare. The furniture was old and dark. A fire burned low in the fireplace, but it gave little warmth. Mary walked to the window and looked out. The land outside was wide and empty. The wind moved across it freely, bending the grass and touching the trees.

Soon, someone knocked on the door.

A woman entered the room. She was tall and strong and wore plain clothes. Her face was serious, and her eyes watched Mary closely.

"This is Mrs Medlock," the woman said. "I will take care of things here."

Mary looked at her and said nothing.

Mrs Medlock spoke in a firm voice. She told Mary what time she must wake. She told her when she would eat and when she would sleep. She said Mary must stay in her room unless she was told to go out. She said many parts of the house were not for children.

"You will not open doors on your own," Mrs Medlock said. "This is not your house to explore."

Mary heard the words and nodded. She did not like the rules, but she did not speak.

After that, Mrs Medlock led Mary into the hall. The hall was long and narrow, with a high ceiling. Doors stood on both sides, all closed. Mary's footsteps echoed as she walked, and the sound followed her.

They passed many rooms. Mrs Medlock did not open the doors. She only pointed and walked on. The house seemed to go on and on. Stairs led up and down. Corridors turned left and right.

Mary began to feel small inside it.

"This house is very large," Mrs Medlock said. "You will learn

your way in time."

Mary watched the doors as they passed them. She wondered what was behind them. Each door looked the same, dark and closed. The silence made her curious.

At the end of the hall, they reached a dining room. A long table stood in the center of the room. One place was set with a plate and a cup. No one else was there.

Mary sat down alone.

A servant brought her food and left the room at once. Mary ate slowly. The room felt too big for one person. Her fork made a small sound each time it touched the plate. The sound seemed loud in the empty space. When she finished, she sat still for a moment.

Everything stayed still.

After the meal, Mary walked again through the halls with Mrs Medlock. They passed tall windows. Outside, the wind moved the trees and grass. Clouds crossed the sky, and light and shadow moved along the walls.

"This place feels empty," Mary said at last.

Mrs Medlock looked at her. "It is a quiet house," she said. "That is how it should be."

They walked up a long stair. The steps were wide and worn. Their feet made a soft sound as they climbed. At the top, another hall waited, just as long and just as still.

Mrs Medlock opened a door and showed Mary a room. "This room is not for you," she said, and closed it again. She

pointed to another door. "And this one as well."

Mary nodded, but she watched carefully.

At last, they returned to Mary's room. Mrs Medlock told her to stay there until evening. Then she left, closing the door behind her.

Mary stood in the middle of the room and waited.

The wind pressed against the house. It moved around the corners and along the walls. Sometimes it sounded like a voice, but when Mary paid attention, it was only air and leaves.

She walked to the window again. The land outside looked gray and cold. Nothing moved except the wind. Mary felt the silence around her and inside her.

Later, a servant brought her food. Again, Mary ate alone. Again, the room felt too large. When she finished, she washed her hands and waited.

When evening came, the light faded early. Shadows filled the corners of the room. The fire burned low, and the air felt cold.

Mary lay on her bed.

She did not hear laughter. She did not hear music. She did not hear people calling to one another.

Only the wind moved outside.

At night, Mary did not sleep well. The bed felt strange, and the room was too quiet. She turned from one side to the other and heard nothing from the house. It did not answer her.

In the morning, light came through the window again. Mary opened her eyes.

Everything stayed still.

She felt less afraid now and more curious.

She stood up, washed, and dressed. No one came to hurry her. No one spoke to her through the door. Mary felt the silence like space around her, and she wondered where it might lead.

She walked to the door and placed her hand on it. She did not open it, but she waited. Nothing moved, as if it was waiting too.

Everything stayed still.

But the silence no longer felt only empty. It made Mary want to see more of the house and learn its many halls and rooms.

Chapter 3 — The Cry in the Night

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Mary went to bed early that evening. The day had felt long, and the house had stayed quiet from morning until night. When she lay down, she waited for a moment, but she heard nothing. The walls did not speak. The halls did not answer her.

Soon, Mary fell asleep.

She did not know how long she slept before she woke again. At first, she did not understand why she was awake. Then she heard a sound.

Someone was crying.

Mary lay still. The sound came again, soft and broken. It rose and fell, and then it stopped. Mary held her breath and waited.

Nothing moved.

She told herself it was nothing. Perhaps it was the wind. She turned her face to the wall and closed her eyes.

Then the sound came again.

It was clearer this time. It was not the wind. It sounded like a child crying in the dark. The sound came from far away, like someone calling through the empty halls.

Mary sat up in bed.

She waited carefully. The crying did not come from her room. It came from somewhere far away, along the long halls and behind many closed doors. Mary's heart beat faster as she heard it.

She slipped out of bed and stood on the cold floor. The air felt heavy and still. Mary walked quietly to the door and opened it a little. The hall outside was dark. No light moved there.

The crying came again.

Mary stepped into the hall. Her feet made no sound on the floor. She stood still, turning her head slowly. The sound seemed to move, first from one side of the house, then from another.

At last, the crying stopped.

Mary waited.

Nothing happened.

She stood in the dark hall for a long time. Nothing moved, as if it had never made a sound. At last, Mary returned to her room and closed the door.

She lay in bed, but she did not sleep again.

In the morning, Mary woke early. The sound of the crying stayed with her. As she washed and dressed, she waited, but she heard only the wind outside the windows.

At breakfast, Mary ate alone, as she had the day before. The room was quiet. A servant came and left without speaking. Mary watched the door after the servant left.

When she finished eating, Mary walked slowly back through the halls. She looked at the doors as she passed them. Each one was closed. Each one was silent.

At last, Mary saw Mrs Medlock.

"Who was crying last night?" Mary asked.

Mrs Medlock stopped and looked at her. "Crying?" she asked. "You must have been dreaming."

"I was awake," Mary answered. "I heard it."

Mrs Medlock shook her head. "This house is old," she said. "The wind moves through it at night. That is all."

"But it sounded like a child," Mary said.

"There are no children crying here," Mrs Medlock answered. "Do not listen to strange sounds."

She turned and walked away.

Mary stood still in the hall. No sounds came.

Later that day, Mary went outside for the first time since her arrival. A servant showed her the door and told her where she could walk. The air felt cold and fresh on her face.

Outside, the wind moved freely across the land. It bent the grass and shook the trees. Mary stood still. The wind made many sounds, but none of them sounded like crying.

Mary walked along a path near the house. The ground felt hard under her feet. The sky was gray, and clouds moved slowly overhead. As she walked, she thought about the sound she had heard.

That evening, Mary went to bed again. She felt tired, but she did not fall asleep at once. She lay very still.

At first, she heard nothing.

Then, very softly, the sound came again.

Someone was crying.

Mary's eyes opened at once. She paid attention carefully. The sound was weak, but it was clear. It rose and fell, just as it had the night before.

Mary did not leave her bed this time. She heard it from under the covers. The sound went on for a short time and then stopped.

In the morning, Mary felt certain. She had not imagined it.

Later that day, Mary met a young servant girl. The girl had a round face and quick hands. She spoke with a friendly voice.

"My name is Martha," the girl said. "I will help you today."

Mary watched her closely. Martha moved easily through the room, opening drawers and setting things in order.

"Martha," Mary said, "does anyone cry in this house at night?"

Martha stopped what she was doing and looked at Mary. For a moment, she did not speak.

"People say it is the wind," Martha said at last.

Mary looked at her. "But is it?" she asked.

Martha lowered her voice. "I should not talk about it," she said. "Mrs Medlock does not like questions."

"But I heard it," Mary said. "It sounded like a child."

Martha nodded slowly. "Aye," she answered. "It does."

Mary watched her face. Martha did not smile.

"The house has many rooms," Martha said. "Some are very far apart."

"Who cries?" Mary asked.

Martha shook her head. "I cannot say," she answered. "It is better not to ask."

She went on with her work, and Mary did not ask again. But as Martha moved around the room, Mary paid attention to every sound.

Everything stayed still.

But now Mary knew the silence was not empty.

Something inside the house was awake.